

General Knowledge

Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Rise of Regional Kingdoms



RISE OF REGIONAL KINGDOMS



Introduction

The **decline of the Mughal Empire** in the early 18th century paved the way for the emergence of several **regional kingdoms** across India. With the weakening of the central authority, powerful regional leaders established their own domains, shaping the **political and cultural landscape** of India. These kingdoms not only consolidated their power but also contributed to the **diversity of art, architecture, and administration**.

Challenges Before the Mughals

External Challenges

- **Nadir Shah's Invasion (1738-39)**
 - **Battle of Karnal (1739):** Nadir Shah defeated the Mughal army and captured **Muhammad Shah**.
 - **Loot of Delhi:** The **Peacock Throne**, **Kohinoor diamond**, and several valuables were taken away.

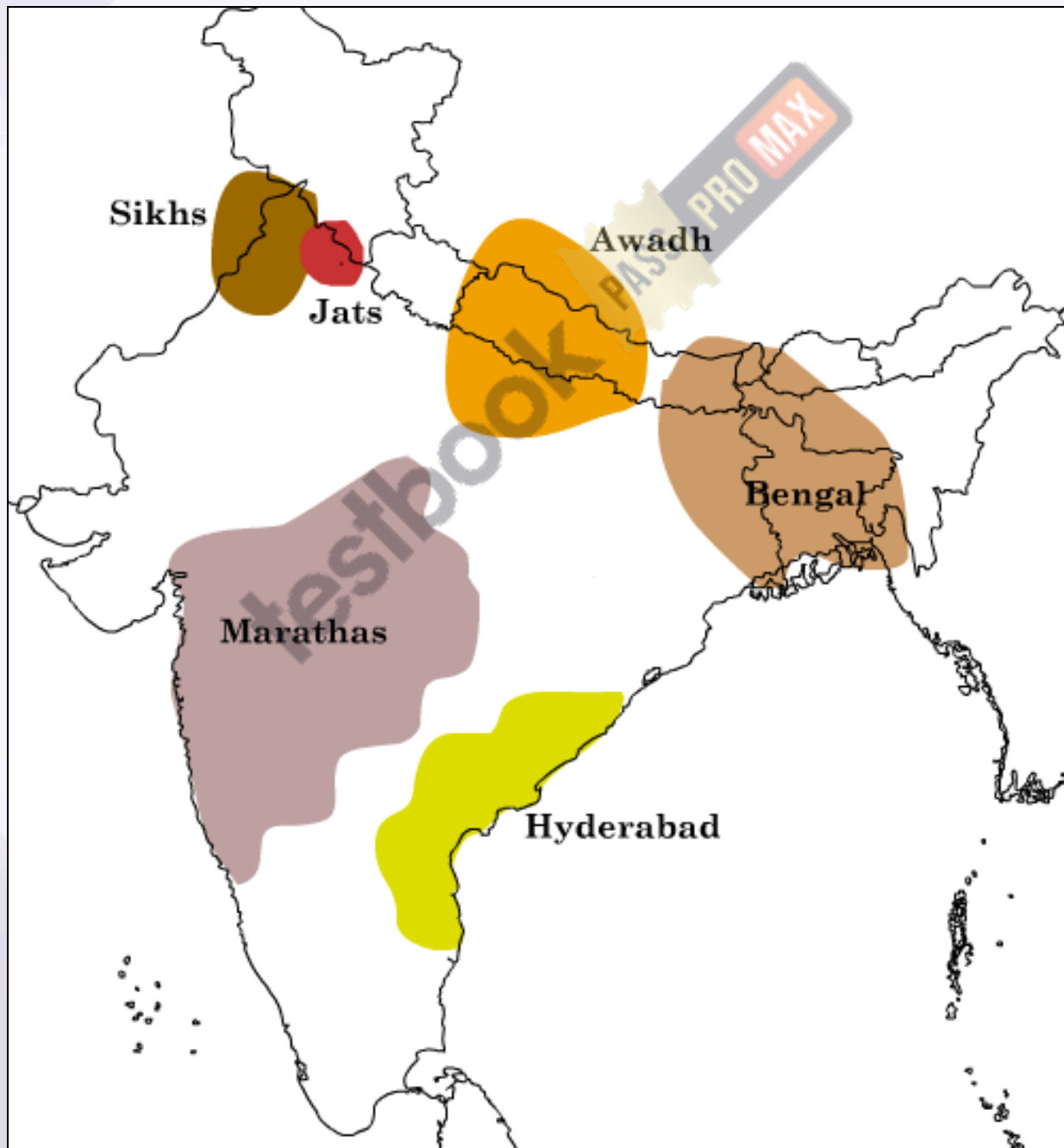
- **Kabul and Indus regions:** These strategic territories were lost, leaving India vulnerable to further attacks.
- **Ahmad Shah Abdali's Invasions**
 - **Delhi was captured in 1757:** Abdali's caretaker took over Mughal affairs.
 - **Third Battle of Panipat (1761):** Abdali defeated the Marathas, weakening their control over Delhi.

Internal Challenges – Weak Rulers After Aurangzeb

- **Bahadur Shah I (1707-1712)**
 - Known as **Shah-i-Bekhabar** (The Careless King).
 - Tried to maintain peace with the **Rajputs, Marathas, and Jats**.
 - Faced a revolt by **Sikh leader Banda Bahadur**.
- **Jahandar Shah (1712-1713)**
 - Became emperor with **Zulfikar Khan's** help.
 - Introduced the **Izara system** to improve finances.
 - **Abolished the Jaziya** tax.
- **Farrukhsiyar (1713-1718)**
 - Installed by the **Sayyid Brothers** after **killing Jahandar Shah**.
 - Followed **religious tolerance** policies and abolished the pilgrimage tax.
 - **Granted the British Farmans (1717)**, unknowingly aiding British expansion.
- **Rafi-ud-Darajat & Rafi-ud-Daula (1719)**
 - Installed by the Sayyid Brothers but **died within a year** due to ill health.
- **Muhammad Shah Rangeela (1719-1748)**
 - Took control by **killing the Sayyid Brothers** with Nizam-ul-Mulk's help.
 - **Defeated by Nadir Shah** in the **Battle of Karnal (1739)**.
- **Ahmad Shah Bahadur (1748-1754)**
 - Left governance to **Udham Bai**, the 'Queen Mother.'
- **Alamgir II (1754-1759)**
 - Witnessed **Abdali's invasion** and the **Battle of Plassey (1757)**.
 - Assassinated in 1759.
- **Shah Alam II (1760-1806)**
 - Defeated in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)** and **Battle of Buxar (1764)**.
 - **Treaty of Allahabad (1765):** Granted the British **Diwani rights** over Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.

- **Akbar Shah II (1806-1837)**
 - Gave the title of **Raja** to **Raja Ram Mohan Roy**.
 - British stopped producing coins in his name in 1835.
- **Bahadur Shah II (1837-1857)**
 - **The last Mughal emperor** was declared the **Emperor of India** during the **Revolt of 1857**.
 - Exiled to **Rangoon** by the British.

Key Regional States and Their Rise



Kingdom	Capital	Founder	Established	Features
Maratha Empire	Raigad	Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj	1674	• Strong military system. • Opposed Mughal rule. • Expanded control across central and north India.
Bengal Subah	Murshidabad	Murshid Quli Khan	1717	• A prosperous economy based on agriculture and trade. • The first region to fall to British power (Battle of Plassey, 1757).
Awadh (Oudh)	Faizabad, Lucknow	Saadat Khan Burhan-ul-Mulk	1722	• Became a cultural hub known for music, poetry, and cuisine. • Annexed by the British in 1856.
Hyderabad State	Hyderabad	Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah I	1724	• Known for its architectural achievements. • Maintained autonomy until 1948.
Mysore Kingdom	Srirangapatna	Hyder Ali	1761	• Tipu Sultan pioneered the use of rockets in warfare. • Resisted British expansion until 1799.
Sikh Empire	Lahore	Maharaja Ranjit Singh	1799	• Unified the Punjab region under Sikh control. • Known for a strong military and effective administration.

Rohilkhand	Bareilly	Ali Mohammad Khan	1737	- Established by Afghan-origin Rohillas. - Known for Persian culture and learning.
Travancore	Thiruvananthapuram	Marthanda Varma	1729	- Defeated the Dutch at the Battle of Colachel (1741). - Focused on trade and temple architecture.
Rajput Kingdoms	Various (Jaipur, Udaipur)	Multiple Rajput rulers	18th cen.	- Preserved traditional culture and values. - Became princely states under British rule.
Carnatic Kingdom	Arcot	Nawabs of Carnatic	1707	- Scene of Anglo-French rivalry. - Eventually absorbed into British territories.
Jats of Bharatpur	Bharatpur	Raja Suraj Mal	1733	- Known for a well-organized army. - Famous for building the Lohagarh Fort.
Bhopal State	Bhopal	Dost Mohammad Khan	1723	- Established by an Afghan-origin noble. - Known for architecture blending Islamic and Rajput styles.
Sindh	Hyderabad (Sindh)	Kalhora Dynasty	1701	- Located in present-day Pakistan. - Known for irrigation networks on the Indus River.

Cooch Behar	Cooch Behar	Maharaja Nilambar	18th century	• Allied with the British in return for autonomy. • Known for temple architecture.
Jaipur State	Jaipur	Maharaja Sawai Jai Singh II	1727	• Founded Jaipur as the first planned city of India. • Known for astronomical observatories (Jantar Mantar).
Baroda (Gaekwad Dynasty)	Baroda	Damaji Rao Gaekwad	1721	• Became a prosperous state under British suzerainty. • Known for the Laxmi Vilas Palace.
Kutch State	Bhuj	Rao Khengarji I	16th century	• Continued as a princely state during British rule. • Known for intricate handicrafts and textiles.
Nagpur Kingdom	Nagpur	Raghoji Bhonsle	18th century	• Controlled parts of central India. • Eventually annexed by the British in 1853.
Coorg Kingdom	Madikeri	Muddu Raja	17th century	• - Known for coffee plantations. • - Became a British province in the 19th century.

Assam (Ahom Kingdom)	Rangpur	Sukapha	13th cen., 18th cen.	- Maintained independence against the Mughals. - Eventually annexed by the British in 1826.
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Key Regional Kingdoms and Their Significance

Awadh (Oudh)

- **Awadh was established by Saadat Khan Burhan-ul-Mulk** in 1722 after declaring autonomy from the Mughal Empire.
- **The capital of Awadh was initially Faizabad** but later shifted to **Lucknow** under Nawab Asaf-ud-Daula.
- **Awadh became a hub for art, culture, and music**, promoting Urdu poetry and fine cuisine.
- **The Bara Imambara in Lucknow was constructed by Asaf-ud-Daula**, showcasing the region's architectural advancement.
- Although Awadh acknowledged **nominal allegiance to the Mughals**, it functioned independently.
- **The British annexed Awadh in 1856**, citing misgovernance, which led to local discontent and became a key cause of the **Revolt of 1857**.

Bengal Subah

- **Murshid Quli Khan established Bengal's autonomy** in 1717, with Murshidabad as its capital.
- **Bengal's economy thrived through agriculture, textile trade, and commerce**, attracting European trading companies.
- **Alivardi Khan later took control of Bengal**, asserting independence while paying tribute to the Mughal emperor.
- **The Battle of Plassey in 1757 marked the defeat of Siraj-ud-Daulah** by the British, leading to the establishment of British control over Bengal.

- **Bengal's dual administration weakened its political strength**, paving the way for deeper British influence.

Hyderabad State

- **Hyderabad was founded by Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah I in 1724**, following his victory over the Mughal viceroy in the **Battle of Shahr-Khedra**.
- **The Nizams ruled Hyderabad as a wealthy state**, known for trade, especially in **diamonds and pearls**.
- **Hyderabad maintained autonomy** during British rule, aligning with both local and colonial interests.
- **Hyderabad's architecture, including Charminar, reflected its cultural vibrancy**.
- The state remained independent until **1948**, when it was **merged with the Indian Union** through military action.

Mysore Kingdom

- **The Mysore Kingdom was initially ruled by the Wodeyars**, with Hyder Ali assuming power in 1761.
- **Hyder Ali built a strong military** and frequently engaged in battles with the Marathas and the British.
- **Tipu Sultan, known as the 'Tiger of Mysore,' modernized the army** and resisted British expansion.
- **Mysore became the first state to use rockets in warfare**, significantly during battles with the British.
- **Tipu Sultan was killed in the Fourth Anglo-Mysore War in 1799**, and Mysore became a princely state under British suzerainty.

Maratha Empire

- **The Maratha Empire was founded by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj in 1674**, with **Raigad as the capital**.
- **The Marathas emerged as a formidable force** challenging the Mughal Empire in the Deccan and northern India.
- **Peshwas led the Maratha expansion** after Shivaji's death, administering territories across India.

- **The Third Battle of Panipat in 1761 resulted in a Maratha defeat** by Ahmad Shah Abdali, weakening their influence.
- Despite internal strife, **the Marathas remained the most powerful regional force** until British expansion in the 19th century.

Sikh Empire

- **The Sikh Empire was established by Maharaja Ranjit Singh** in 1799, with **Lahore as its capital**.
- **Ranjit Singh unified various Sikh misls (confederacies)**, creating a powerful kingdom in the Punjab region.
- **Ranjit Singh modernized the army** and signed the **Treaty of Amritsar with the British** to maintain peace.
- **The Sikh Empire was known for religious tolerance**, attracting people of various faiths.
- **The empire weakened after Ranjit Singh's death**, leading to its annexation by the British after the **Second Anglo-Sikh War in 1849**.

Travancore Kingdom

- **Travancore was founded by Marthanda Varma in 1729**, with **Thiruvananthapuram as its capital**.
- **Marthanda Varma defeated the Dutch in the Battle of Colachel (1741)**, marking a significant victory over a European power.
- **The Travancore rulers promoted Malayalam literature** and temple architecture, supporting local culture.
- Travancore's army was **modernized along Western lines**, contributing to its military strength.
- **The kingdom retained its autonomy until 1947**, when it merged with the Indian Union.

Rohilkhand

- **Rohilkhand was founded by Ali Mohammad Khan in 1737**, with **Bareilly as its capital**.
- **The Rohillas, an Afghan community, established Rohilkhand** during the decline of the Mughal Empire.
- **Rohilkhand became a centre of Persian learning and culture**.

- The region was **frequently engaged in conflict with both the Marathas and the British.**
- **The British annexed Rohilkhand in 1774** after defeating the Rohillas with the help of the Nawab of Awadh.

Jat Kingdom of Bharatpur

- **The Jat Kingdom of Bharatpur was founded by Churaman and Badan Singh in 1722.**
- **Raja Suraj Mal expanded the Jat territories** to include Agra, Mathura, and Aligarh.
- **The Lohagarh Fort in Bharatpur was renowned for its strength,** repelling several British attacks.
- The Jat rulers managed to maintain independence and later **aligned with the British as a princely state.**
- **The Jat state disintegrated into smaller principalities** after the death of Suraj Mal.

Developments in Art, Architecture, and Culture

- **Bara Imambara:** Built by **Asaf-ud-Daula** in Lucknow.
- **Pink City of Jaipur:** Founded by **Sawai Jai Singh II**, who also built **astronomical observatories** in Jaipur, Delhi, and Ujjain.
- **Padmanabhapuram Palace:** Built in Kerala by Travancore rulers.
- **Urdu Poetry:** Flourished with poets like **Mirza Ghalib, Sauda, and Nazir.**
- **Punjabi Literature:** **Heer Ranjha** was written by **Waris Shah.**
- **Malayalam Literature:** Supported by **Travancore rulers** like Marthanda Varma.

Conclusion

The **rise of regional kingdoms** after the decline of the Mughal Empire led to a **fragmented political landscape** in India. While kingdoms like the **Marathas, Sikhs, and Hyderabad** flourished, their inability to **unite** allowed **British colonization** to gradually take over. This era of **regional states** was a transitional phase, shaping the **cultural and political identity** of modern India.